MODULE 35 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

Exam Mechanics

Reading the question, the qualifier words, the eight distractor patterns, and 130 minutes.

DOMAIN Cross-cutting EXAM WEIGHT All MODULE 35 of 35

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The question tells you which answer it wants. The **qualifier** is an instruction, not decoration, and several options are usually technically correct.

The anatomy of a question

- **The scenario** sets the situation and, crucially, contains the **constraints** that eliminate options.
- **The stem** asks the question, and carries the **qualifier**: most cost-effective, least operational overhead, fastest.
- **The options** are usually four, of which one or two are wrong outright and the rest are plausible.
- Read the **stem before the options**. Reading options first makes you evaluate each against the scenario rather than against the requirement.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Read the last sentence of the scenario twice. The constraint that decides the question is very often the final clause before the stem.

The qualifier words

QUALIFIER	WHAT IT ELIMINATES
MOST cost-effective	Options that work but cost more. All of them may be correct
LEAST operational overhead	Anything you build, run or maintain yourself
MOST secure	Anything a privileged user can reverse, or that widens access
FASTEST to implement	Anything requiring procurement, provisioning or a migration
MINIMUM changes to the application	Anything requiring a rewrite. Favours transparent mechanisms
Without downtime	Anything replacing a resource, or requiring a restart
MOST resilient	Single-AZ, single-Region, and single-instance answers

ON THE EXAM

Least operational overhead is the most common qualifier on this exam, and it consistently favours managed services over anything custom.

Multiple response questions

- **Choose TWO** or **Choose THREE** tells you exactly how many. Selecting a different number is marked wrong.
- **There is no partial credit.** Two of three correct scores the same as none.
- They frequently pair an **immediate mitigation** with a **structural fix**, or address **two stated stakeholders**.
- If you are confident about one answer, use it to narrow the rest: the second answer usually addresses a **different** part of the requirement.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Module 13's scenario 2 is the shape: the business wants it working today, engineering wants no long-lived HTTP requests. Two needs, two answers.

The eight distractor patterns

PATTERN	HOW IT LOOKS
The failed experiment	The scenario says they already tried it, and it did not work
Over-engineering	More robust than required, and more expensive. Correct, and wrong
The dated recommendation	Was best practice, and AWS changed something
The overcorrection	Applies a real fact too broadly
Works, but costs more	Technically achieves it, with extra components or charges
Solves half	Answers one of two stated requirements
Invented behaviour	States a limitation or requirement that does not exist
The absolute	Contains never, always, cannot, or only. Usually too strong

ON THE EXAM

This course used all eight deliberately, roughly 150 times. Recognising the pattern is often faster than evaluating the technical claim.

The failed experiment, and over-engineering

- **The failed experiment:** when a scenario states they already tried something, that thing is not the answer, and it is usually a strong hint about the real cause.
- "They increased capacity to 30,000 and it did not help" tells you the constraint is not capacity. That is evidence, not background.
- **Over-engineering:** exceeding an agreed target is not a safer answer, it is a more expensive one.
- If the scenario states an RTO of 24 hours, an answer delivering 5 minutes at ten times the cost is wrong.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Both patterns exploit the same instinct: doing more feels safer. On this exam, doing exactly what was asked is the correct answer.

The dated recommendation, and the overcorrection

- **The dated recommendation** is often voiced by a character: a colleague, an architect, or a runbook. That framing is the signal.
- This course used it five times: Incident Manager, ARC readiness check, Terraform's DynamoDB lock, CodeDeploy for ECS, and Origin Access Identity.
- **The overcorrection** is the mirror error: knowing CloudTrail Lake closed and concluding CloudTrail closed.
- Closed to new customers is not withdrawn. Retiring a product is not retiring every feature bearing its name.

> ON THE EXAM
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> When a scenario quotes somebody's recommendation, treat the quote as a hypothesis to test, not as context to accept.

Works but costs more, and solves half

- **Works but costs more:** the option achieves the outcome by adding a component that something already present does natively.
- An ALB in front of a Lambda that API Gateway already fronts. A second NAT gateway when a free endpoint removes the traffic.
- **Solves half:** the scenario states two requirements, and each of two options answers exactly one.
- The word **separately**, or a sentence beginning **they also need**, is usually announcing the second requirement.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Count the requirements before you read the options. If there are two, an option answering one of them is a distractor by construction.

Invented behaviour, and absolutes

- **Invented behaviour** states a limitation or dependency that does not exist: "failover routing requires a calculated health check".
- These are usually the easiest to eliminate, because the claim sounds oddly specific and you have never met it.
- **Absolutes** contain never, always, cannot or only. Sometimes an absolute is true, so check rather than eliminating reflexively.
- True absolutes on this exam: a CNAME cannot exist at the zone apex; an explicit Deny always wins; a subnet cannot span AZs.

> ON THE EXAM
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> "Security group references never work across VPCs" is too strong and is wrong. "An explicit Deny always wins" is absolute and is true. Read each one.

Working an option list

- **1. Count the requirements** in the scenario, and note the qualifier in the stem.
- **2. Scan for the disqualifying clause**: overlapping CIDRs, no public IP, must survive deletion. One clause often removes three options.
- **3. Eliminate what does not work at all**, which is usually one or two options.
- **4. Apply the qualifier** to what remains. This is the step people skip, and it is where the mark is.

> ON THE EXAM
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> If two options survive and both work, you have not applied the qualifier. Go back to the stem rather than choosing between them on instinct.

The arithmetic of 130 minutes

- **65 questions in 130 minutes is exactly two minutes each.** Most take under one, and a few take four.
- A useful checkpoint: you should be at **question 33 by the 65-minute mark**. If you are behind, start flagging sooner.
- **Never spend more than three minutes** on a question on the first pass. Flag it, choose something, and move.
- Always **record an answer before flagging**. An unanswered flagged question you run out of time on scores zero; a guess does not.

> ON THE EXAM
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> There is no negative marking. An unanswered question is a guaranteed zero, and a guess between two survivors is a coin flip you are ahead on.

Flagging, and the review pass

- Flag anything where you eliminated to two and guessed, or where a term was unfamiliar.
- **Do not flag questions you answered confidently.** A review pass of thirty flags is not a review pass.
- Later questions sometimes **remind you of something** that unlocks an earlier one. That is the main value of reviewing.
- **Change an answer only with a reason.** A remembered fact is a reason. A feeling that the other one looks better is not.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Most changed answers on a review pass are changed from right to wrong. Change when you can name what you now know that you did not before.

Scoring, and what it means for strategy

- **15 of the 65 questions are unscored** and are not marked as such. A bizarre question may simply be one of them.
- **Scoring is compensatory.** You need 720 overall, and there is **no minimum per domain**.
- So a weak area does not fail you. Strength elsewhere genuinely compensates, which is why breadth beats depth here.
- The scaled score runs 100 to 1000, so **720 is not 72 per cent**. Do not try to convert it while sitting there.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Two questions in a row that feel unreasonably obscure is not a signal about your preparation. Roughly one question in four is unscored.

When you genuinely do not know

- **Eliminate on principle rather than fact.** Over-engineered, invented behaviour, or an absolute you doubt: those go first.
- **Prefer the managed service** over the thing you build, unless the question rewards control.
- **Prefer the answer that changes least.** AWS questions rarely reward rebuilding when a setting exists.
- **Prefer the newer mechanism** where you recognise both, since the exam tracks AWS's own recommendations.

> ON THE EXAM
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> These heuristics are not guesses. They encode how AWS writes questions, and they will beat a coin flip reliably.

The week before

- **Re-watch module 33.** It is the highest density of things other material will have taught you wrongly.
- **Drill module 34.** The discriminating questions are what you want available instantly, not the full comparisons.
- Take the practice exams **timed**, and review every question you got right for the wrong reason as carefully as the ones you missed.
- Do not learn new services in the final week. Consolidate what you have; a half-known service is a distractor you will fall for.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The most valuable revision is the questions you answered correctly by luck. They are the ones that will not repeat.

The day itself

- **130 minutes is enough** if you keep moving. Nobody fails this exam for lack of time; people fail it by over-thinking twelve questions.
- Read the **last sentence of every scenario twice**. The deciding constraint is very often there.
- When two options survive, **go back to the qualifier** rather than choosing between them on feel.
- You get a **pass or fail indication at the end**, with the detailed score report following within a few working days.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The single highest-value habit in this module: read the stem before the options, and read the last sentence of the scenario twice.

> A question describes a team needing to reduce EC2 costs. Four options are given: buy Reserved Instances, move to Graviton, right-size using Compute Optimizer, and migrate to Spot. The stem asks for the approach with the LEAST operational overhead.
>
> All four options would genuinely reduce cost.

How should the qualifier be used?

A. It selects between four working options by which requires the least ongoing management, not by which saves most

B. It means choose the cheapest option regardless of effort

C. It is decoration; pick the largest saving

D. It means eliminate any option that is not managed by AWS

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the qualifier be used?

A Selects by ongoing management

The scenario states all four reduce cost. The qualifier is therefore the only thing distinguishing them, and it asks about effort, not savings.

B Means cheapest

Conflates two different qualifiers. Most cost-effective and least operational overhead frequently point at different answers.

C Decoration

The premise of this whole module. When several options work, the qualifier is the entire question.

D Eliminate anything unmanaged

Close, and too crude. Spot is fully managed and carries high operational overhead because of interruption handling.

THE SIGNAL

Option D is the instructive near miss: managed and low-overhead are not the same thing. Spot is managed and demands constant handling.

> A question describes a database that is throttling. It notes that the team already doubled the provisioned capacity last month with no improvement. Two of the four options propose increasing capacity further, by different means.
>
> The stem asks for the root cause and the fix.

What does the second sentence tell you?

A. It is evidence that the constraint is not total capacity, which eliminates both capacity-increasing options

B. It is background detail explaining the team's frustration

C. It suggests the previous increase was too small

D. It means the answer must be a different service entirely

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What does the second sentence tell you?

A Evidence that eliminates two options

A stated failed experiment is data. It removes both options that repeat it, halving the list before you evaluate anything technical.

B Background detail

AWS questions rarely include a sentence with no function. Detail about something already attempted is almost always there to eliminate options.

C The increase was too small

Doubling and seeing no change at all points at a different kind of limit, not an insufficient one.

D Must be a different service

Over-reads it. The fix is usually a different setting or design in the same service, such as a partition key or an index.

THE SIGNAL

Two options can be eliminated before any AWS knowledge is applied. That is what the failed-experiment pattern gives you.

> A question presents four options. One says a feature 'cannot be used across accounts'. Another says a service 'always encrypts data in transit by default'. You are unsure about both claims.
>
> The other two options describe mechanisms you recognise.

How should you treat the two absolute statements?

A. Treat each as a claim to test. Some absolutes are true, so check rather than eliminating both reflexively

B. Eliminate both, because absolutes are always distractors

C. Prefer both, because specific claims signal the correct answer

D. Ignore them and choose between the other two

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should you treat the two absolute statements?

A Test each claim

Most absolutes are too strong, and several on this exam are true: a CNAME cannot exist at the apex, an explicit Deny always wins, Direct Connect is not encrypted by default.

B Eliminate both

The rule of thumb, applied without judgement. It would have you eliminate several correct answers this course has taught.

C Prefer both

Inverts the heuristic. Specificity is not evidence of correctness; invented behaviour is often very specific.

D Ignore them

Discards two of four options without evaluation, which is guessing with extra steps.

THE SIGNAL

Note that option B is itself an absolute. Rules of thumb are useful and are not laws, and this exam rewards judgement over reflex.

> With 20 minutes remaining you have 8 questions unanswered and 11 flagged for review. Three of the unanswered ones are long scenarios you skipped.
>
> You are unsure how to spend the remaining time.

What is the best use of the last 20 minutes?

A Answer all 8 unanswered questions first, even by elimination, then review flags with whatever remains

B Work carefully through the three long scenarios, since they carry the most detail

C Review all 11 flagged questions, since you have partial knowledge of those

D Divide the time evenly between unanswered and flagged questions

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best use of the last 20 minutes?

A Answer the unanswered first

An unanswered question is a guaranteed zero. A flagged one already has an answer, so reviewing it can gain a mark or lose one.

B The three long scenarios

Spends most of the remaining time on three questions while five others stay at zero. Length does not correlate with marks.

C Review the flags

Reviewing an answered question has an uncertain payoff in both directions. Answering an unanswered one has a strictly positive expected value.

D Split evenly

Feels balanced and ignores that the two activities have very different expected returns.

THE SIGNAL

There is no negative marking, so an unanswered question is the only thing on the paper with a guaranteed value of zero. Fix those first.

> A question asks for the MOST cost-effective way to reduce a large NAT gateway bill. Most traffic goes to S3 in the same Region. Two options work: a gateway endpoint for S3, and moving the workload to a public subnet with public IPs.
>
> Both would remove the NAT gateway data processing charge.

Which wins, and why?

A The gateway endpoint: it is free, requires no architectural change, and does not expose instances

B The public subnet, since removing the NAT gateway entirely saves the hourly charge too

C Either, since the qualifier only concerns cost

D Neither, since the qualifier requires the cheapest possible answer regardless of security

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which wins, and why?

A The gateway endpoint

Free, no architectural change, and instances stay private. Cost-effective means good value, not lowest possible cost at any other price.

B Public subnet

The trap. It does remove the hourly charge, and public IPv4 addresses are charged per hour each, and every instance becomes internet-reachable.

C Either

Two options are rarely equally correct on this exam. The qualifier exists to separate them.

D Neither

Misreads cost-effective as cheapest at any cost. AWS never rewards an answer that trades security for a saving.

THE SIGNAL

Cost-effective is not the same as cheapest. An option that saves money by weakening security is a wrong answer on this exam, every time.

The five things to carry forward

- **The qualifier is the instruction.** If two options both work, you have not applied it yet.
- **Count the requirements, then scan for the disqualifying clause.** One constraint often removes three options.
- **A stated failed experiment is evidence**, and it eliminates every option that repeats it.
- **Answer everything.** No negative marking means an unanswered question is the only guaranteed zero.
- **Cost-effective is not cheapest**, and over-engineering is not safe. Do exactly what was asked.

> ON THE EXAM
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> That completes the teaching. Next: four practice exams, worked the same way, so you can drill everything in this module.